freedom of action, the Soviets made no exceptions. By 1928 and the launch of the first Five-Year Plan, there were government officials, party functionaries and secret police informants in every neighbourhood and village, and between them they controlled every aspect of life: all businesses from power plants to cabbage farms; all newspapers and radio stations; all universities, schools and youth groups; all hospitals and clinics; all voluntary and religious organisations; all sporting and scientific associations; all parks, museums and cinemas.

If a dozen people came together to play football, hike in the woods or do some charity work, the party and the secret police had to be there too, represented by the local party cell or NKVD agent. The speed and efficiency of modern information technology meant that all these party cells and NKVD agents were always just a telegram or phone call away from Moscow. Information about suspicious persons and activities was fed into a countrywide, cross-referenced system of card catalogues. Known as *kartoteki*, these catalogues contained information from work records, police files, residence cards and other forms of social registrations and, by the 1930s, had become the primary mechanism for surveilling and controlling the Soviet population.[82]

This made it feasible for Stalin to seek control over the totality of Soviet life. One crucial example was the campaign to collectivise Soviet farming. For centuries, economic, social and private life in the thousands of villages of the sprawling Tsarist Empire was managed by several traditional institutions: the local commune, the parish church, the private farm, the local market and above all the family. In the mid-1920s, the Soviet Union was still an overwhelmingly agrarian economy. About 82 per cent of the total population lived in villages, and 83 per cent of the workforce was engaged in farming.[83] But if each peasant family made its own decisions about what to grow, what to buy and how much to charge for their produce, it greatly limited the ability of Moscow officials to themselves plan and control social and economic activities. What if the officials decided on a major agrarian reform, but the peasant families rejected it? So when in 1928 the Soviets came up with their first Five-Year Plan for the development of the Soviet Union, the most important item on the agenda was to collectivise farming.

The idea was that in every village all the families would join a kolkhoz – a collective farm. They would hand over to the kolkhoz all their property –